

THE EX-FILES

A Crossword Book for Men Who Are Absolutely Fine

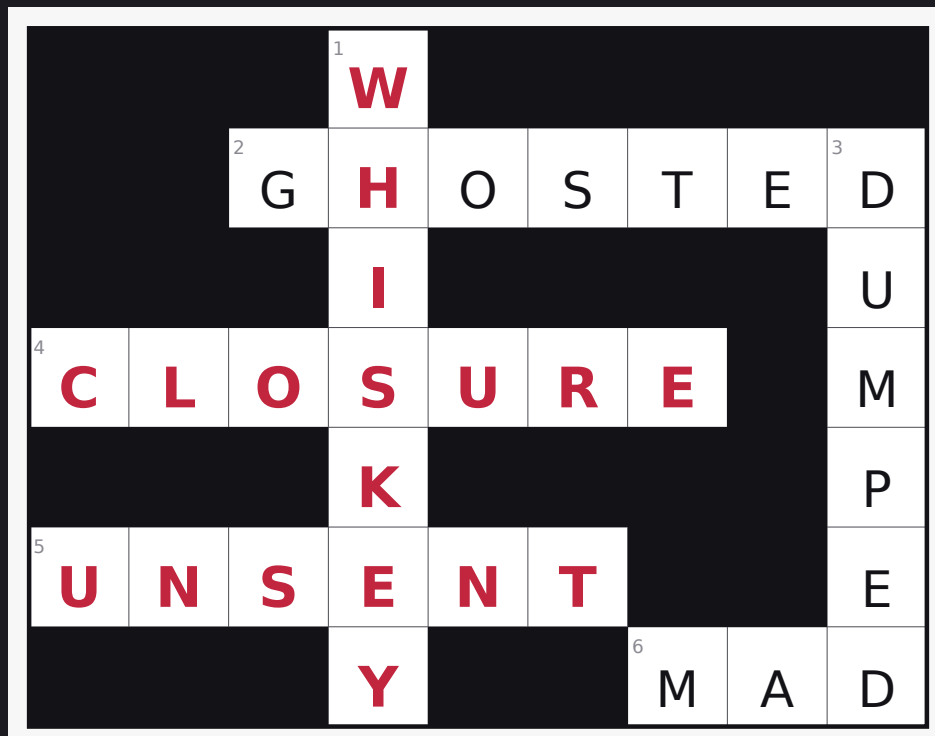
- **A UNSENT** The bravest texts you ever composed
- **D WHISKEY** Coping, but with a label and a story
- **A CLOSURE** What you can't get from an app.

**Eight puzzles about her, the dog, and the group chat
that held you together.**

EIGHT PUZZLES

FULL ANSWER KEY

18+ ADULT HUMOUR



The gift for the man who says he is fine.

Before we begin

This book is a joke. It is also a real crossword book. It can be both.

Every grid in here was built by hand-writing a themed answer list and then weaving the words together until they interlocked, so every letter you see in a square is doing a job. If a clue makes you laugh and then immediately feel something, that is the intended effect, and you should not worry about it.

The tone is adult: there is swearing, there is drinking, and there is one clue about the group chat that will hit too close to home. If you are buying this for somebody's birthday, congratulations, you have excellent taste and no supervision.

How the puzzles work

These are freeform crosswords. Words run across and down, and they cross wherever they happen to share a letter.

That means some squares are crossed by two words and some are not. Start with the words that cross something, then work outward, the way you would with any crossword. Every answer is a real word between 3 and 8 letters, and every one of them is checked against the grid before the book is printed. The theme never changes: her, him, the dog, the group chat, and your ongoing recovery.

Numbers in the top-left corner of a word's first square send you to the ACROSS and DOWN lists printed under each grid.

Stuck? Every answer is in the back. Try not to go there in the first hour.

If you finish all eight puzzles, you have officially processed the breakup and may now talk about something else at parties.

HOUSE RULES

Ground Rules of the Breakup

Ten rules, written down for your own protection. Tear this page out if you must, but you will want it again by Thursday.

- 1.** Nobody in the group chat needs to hear about her sister's wedding. Ever. Again.
- 2.** You are allowed exactly one (1) unsent text per month. Draft it, read it, delete it, sleep.
- 3.** The dog was always going to go with her. You knew that. You bought the dog food. You knew.
- 4.** Do not ask her new man's friends what he does for a living. He is an accountant. Let it go.
- 5.** If you say 'I'm fine' with your whole chest at brunch, someone will hand you a drink and change the subject. That is a friend.
- 6.** Watching her stories at 2 a.m. counts as contact. You know this. Stop it.
- 7.** The gym membership is a tattoo now. It costs the same and it hurts the same.
- 8.** You may keep one (1) song. Not the whole playlist. One.
- 9.** Never text her mom. Her mom likes you. That is the trap.
- 10.** Every rule on this page is negotiable after ten p.m. That is why it is printed here instead of saved on your phone.

THE GROUP CHAT

The Group Chat Glossary

Ten messages you will receive in the next thirty days, translated.

ARE YOU UP

Code for: I need to say something about her immediately, and it cannot wait until morning.

NO WAY

Confirmation that the thing you just said is both true and completely insane.

TOTALLY FINE

The official diagnosis. It is not a compliment.

WE'RE NOT DOING THAT

A plan, vetoed for your own good. Accept it.

COME OUT

Dinner, two hours, one beer, then home. Non-negotiable, lightly enforced.

SHE TEXTED?

The emergency that gets everybody off the couch at midnight.

DRINK WATER

The last message in the thread, always sent at 3:04 a.m., by the one who is awake.

I'M PICKING YOU UP

No discussion, no options, arriving in nine minutes.

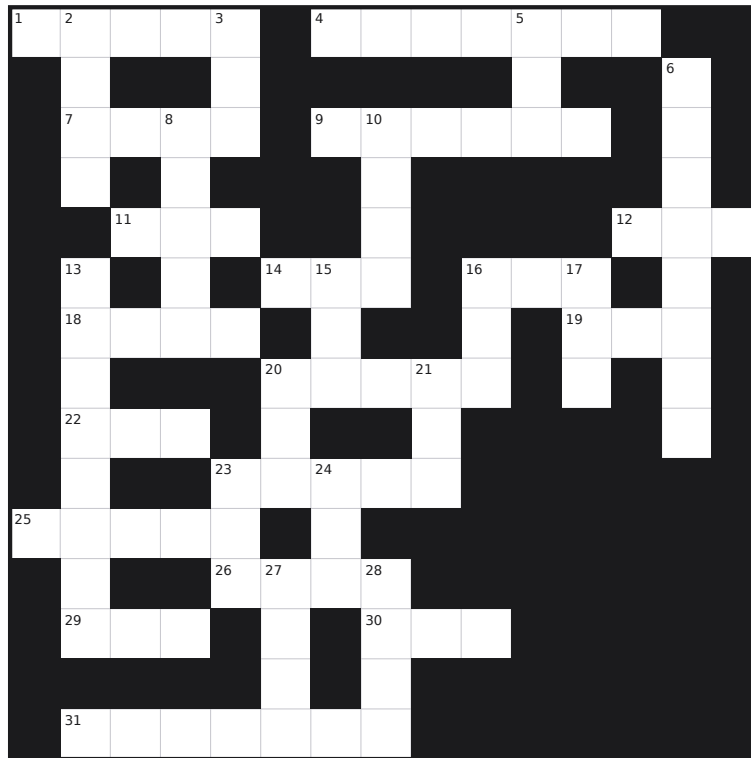
NEW GUY

Two words that end a good evening abruptly.

I SAID WHAT

Quote confirmation, sent with a screenshot you do not want to see.

It's Not You, It's the Puzzle



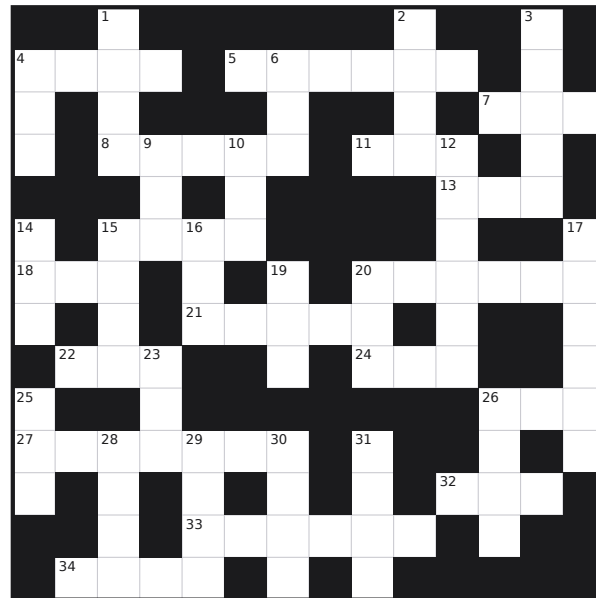
ACROSS

1. Stage whisper
4. What your face looks like at other people's weddings
7. Her status. Also your record collection.
9. What you did on the app while in a queue
11. What you put on your knuckles after the wall thing
12. What the flag was, per your sister
14. What you still do, per the IOU
16. What she said grew on you. She meant it badly.
18. People you now search for at 1 a.m.
19. What she said you never appreciated
20. The noun you keep saying you need
22. What's due, and what she said you were
23. What you're told you'll find. Terms unclear.
25. The real rebound
26. The condition of your pillow, mildly
29. What you claim to smell so you can leave early
30. What you claim to be, to skip brunch
31. What you cannot look at, and looked at

DOWN

2. Your primary form of communication now
3. Night before
5. What the lawyer wants, up front
6. What the venue, the ring, and you all are
8. Fancy shell stuff you couldn't afford for her
10. What both mothers somehow blamed
13. What you swore you would never be caught doing
15. What it became
16. What your new tattoo is made of. Regret is later.
17. What you do about her to strangers at the bar
20. What is in your bonnet about her new guy
21. What you shaved three years off of online
23. What you're on now, alone, at her mom's house
24. What you had, then lost, then found at the gym
27. What the songs do, in your throat
28. What you don't want and will take anyway

The Five Stages, in Ink



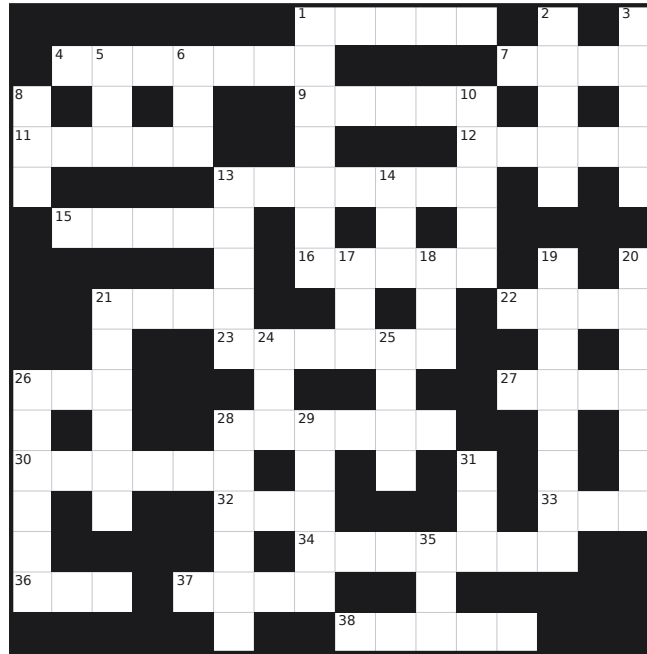
ACROSS

4. The car you sold to afford the ring
5. What two a.m. does to your thoughts, fast
7. Your ride home at two a.m., alone, with the radio off
8. Lightheaded
11. What the fight technically was
13. What you loudly promised to get
15. What you insist you are not
18. Liquid coping, served in a pint
20. Basement
21. What you do about the whole thing, occasionally
22. What her family reunion resembled
24. What your cousin says you should look into
26. Word you weren't allowed to say even ironically
27. The action you stopped 90 percent of the way through
32. What the group chat thinks you are for talking to her cousin
33. What the shower is for, and the parking garage
34. What you take at nine p.m. with a podcast on

DOWN

1. Who she said did everything, before she left
2. Angel ring
3. What you claim were seasonal allergies
4. What you think you look like now
6. What you do her friends with, awkwardly
9. Paper evidence of the forty bucks you borrowed
10. What stress did to your forehead
12. What you do in self-pity, shirtless, with snacks
14. A cheap shot at her new man, online, at 1 a.m.
15. What the bartender called you at closing
16. Where you are emotionally, and how you eat sushi
17. What you did on the doorstep on a Tuesday
19. What the group chat says you're guilty of
20. What she called you when she was done with you
23. What she said would fix your car, and your attitude
25. What the numbers look like, per her mother
26. Your 35th birthday gift to yourself
28. Region
29. Where every new relationship starts
30. The panel you lied to, to their faces
31. How you insist the painting was

Two A.M. Typing Lessons



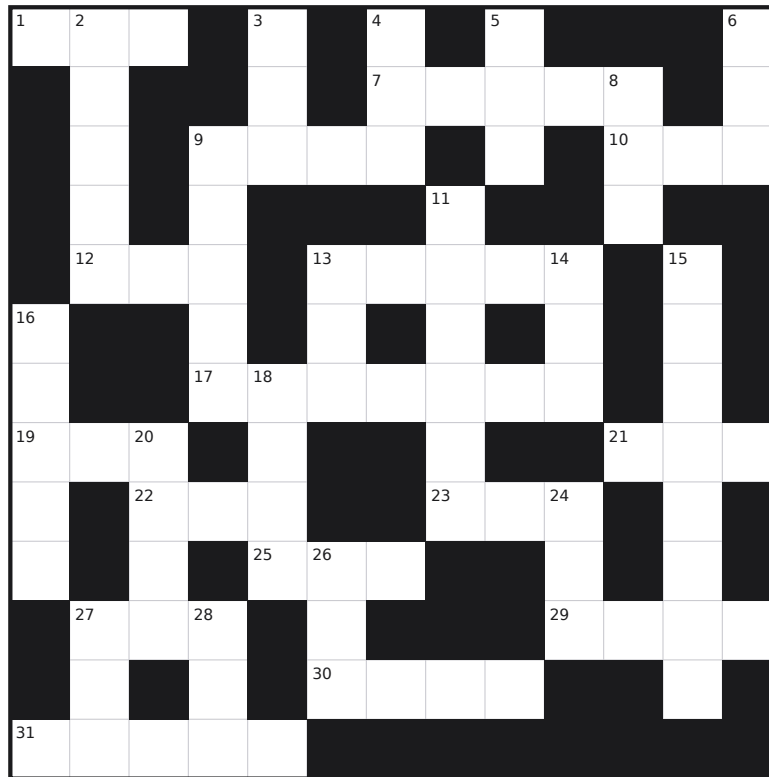
ACROSS

1. How you explained it to her mother
4. Big wave
7. Just, or a midway
9. Nose sound
11. Head skin
12. The size of the fish population you're told about
13. To cry openly, per your brother's review
15. What the block party heard about you
16. Wheel rod
21. What the kitchen is, and mildly what you are
22. Dock
23. The adjective in every draft in your notes app
26. Big tub
27. The noise you made opening the vet bill
28. Against the slope
30. The state of the item, and also you
32. What the group chat says you're guilty of
33. Corn unit
34. Left on read, permanently, by a coward
36. What she said the two of you needed
37. Where you land when the dog picks her
38. What you're waiting for, like a house cat

DOWN

1. Talk over
2. What the milk, and you, are
3. The mode you claim to be in now
5. Where the plenty of other fish allegedly live
6. What you do now at four in the afternoon
8. Fire leftover
10. Blacksmith's shop
13. Horn metal
14. Term of endearment, or a warning
17. What you want to adopt so you can feel again
18. What you insist you still are, at 34
19. Legally undone, with a fee attached
20. Your self-description in any online form
21. Way of doing
24. Unrequested advice from the group chat
25. What you walk down at everyone else's wedding
26. What you claim you're doing, alone, in a car
28. The bravest texts you ever composed
29. Door part she said you should have been
31. Not in
35. What your brother calls you now

The Group Chat Is Typing...



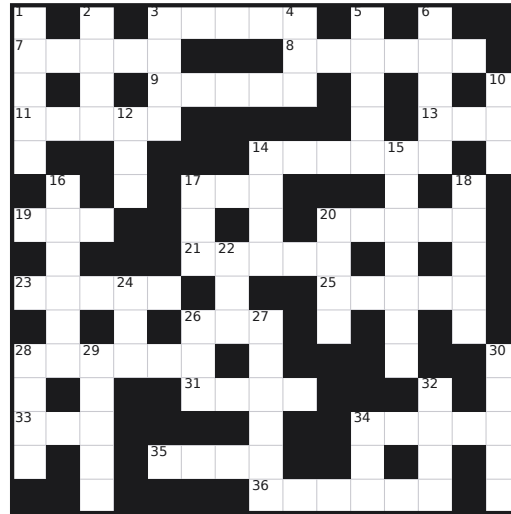
ACROSS

1. What you loudly promised to get
7. What you are pretending to be in front of a mortgage
9. The season you were in briefly
10. Nest item
12. Slalom gear
13. What the group chat turned into over the venue
17. What the guy in the group chat won't stop doing
19. Pronoun you now use for the dog
21. Fire leftover
22. Your general vibe, per the algorithm
23. January's most popular address
25. What you swore you'd do, and absolutely won't
27. What her therapist said got bruised
29. Sand hill
30. Your reported feeling level, for the record
31. What the group chat insists you need immediately

DOWN

2. What you order for two when you forget
3. Paper evidence of the forty bucks you borrowed
4. What her father clearly thought you were
5. What you are no longer half of
6. She got custody. Obviously.
8. What the group chat truly wants
9. What the shower is for, quietly
11. What the shower is for, and the parking garage
13. How many times you re-read the text
14. What the group chat calls you when you text her
15. Cowardice with a good Wi-Fi connection
16. Theatre guide
18. People you now search for at 1 a.m.
20. A pull from the bottle at a children's party
24. What you tell everyone you are not
26. Coffee server
27. Slippery fish
28. What you have to, eventually

She Took the Dog



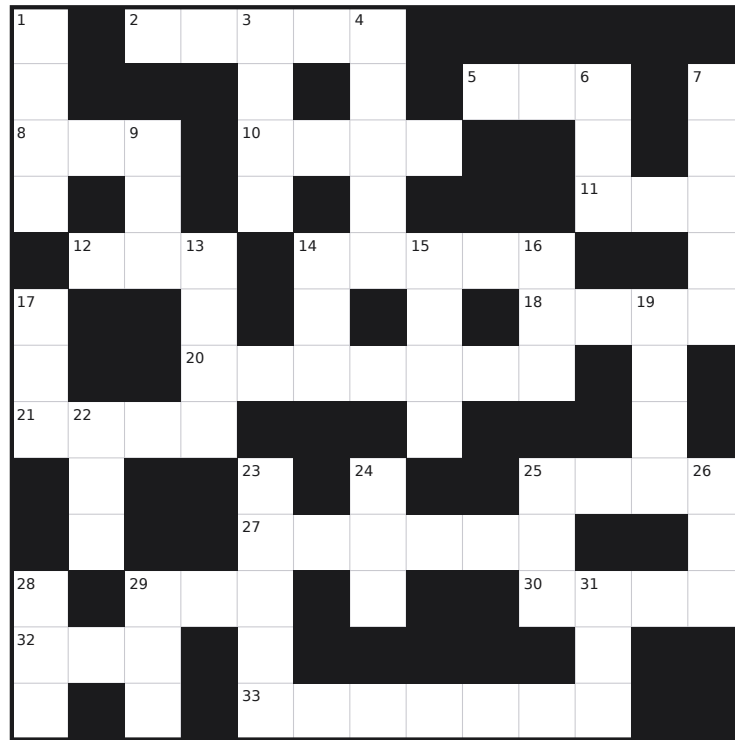
ACROSS

3. What she told everyone the whole thing was
7. Greeting
8. Relationship status: complicated but actually no
9. Compass direction
11. Honourable
13. What she called it; what you called talking
14. Hard to find
17. What the group chat believes itself to be
19. What you called him. He's probably fine.
20. Belonging to whom
21. What nobody in the thread will accept
23. What your sister says you're going through
25. What you are pretending to be in front of a mortgage
26. What you do out of every group event
28. What you did on the third date, mid-appetizer
31. What you now have to do for her half of the couch
33. Finish
34. Discovered
35. What you cook now: eggs, at 10 p.m.
36. What 'I'm fine' is, structurally

DOWN

1. Object you are staring at right now, at 1 a.m.
2. What you became on the couch
3. What you loudly claim to be
4. Fire leftover
5. Beneath
6. State of the union, and of the fridge
10. What you shaved three years off of online
12. Where you now park and stare at the windshield
14. Where you sleep now, by choice, spiritually
15. What you can't get from an app, apparently
16. What the wellness podcast told you to repeat
17. Where the group chat convenes to fix you
18. Drafts you wrote, polished, and never sent
20. How you got when her mom called
22. What you have yet to give her, hopefully
24. What you can't do your hair with because you're out
26. What you wrote at 2 a.m. and deleted at 2:04
27. Shelled swimmer
28. The fifth food group
29. Back-of-book list
30. What her last text to you did over three weeks
32. What the carpet is now called in your apartment
34. The excuse for skipping her cousin's wedding

Blocked, Unblocked, Blocked



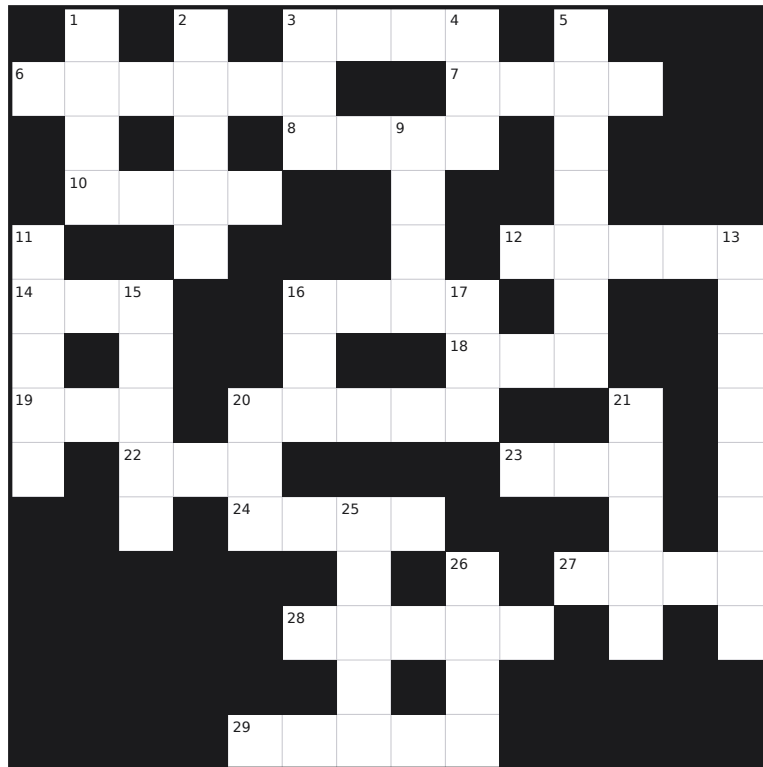
ACROSS

2. What happened, and what the check should be
5. What her father clearly thought you were
8. Slalom gear
10. Three dots that ruined your Tuesday
11. Two thousand pounds
12. What you became on the couch for six weeks
14. What the group chat turned into over the venue
18. People you now search for at 1 a.m.
20. The activity your thumbs regret
21. What the group chat double-dogged you into
25. What you sent. Bold. Unwise.
27. Wildlife trip
29. Pod vegetable
30. Volcano flow
32. What you are no longer half of
33. Blow up

DOWN

1. What you sent to apologize. Wrong address.
3. How she was for everything except the breakup
4. Word the internet taught her for you
6. What you threw. Also what you're getting.
7. What you do at your roommate for 40 minutes
9. Paper evidence of the forty bucks you borrowed
13. What her dog now calls somebody else
14. Allegedly a thing people are still having
15. What came to your parade specifically
16. What she said you were to her mother
17. State of the union, and of your playlist
19. What the bartender did on your third order
22. Suiting the moment
23. Way it's used
24. What you are. Entirely.
25. Nothing at all
26. Long stretch of time
28. What the numbers look like, per her mother
29. Peas come in one
31. Big primate

Closure (Not Included)



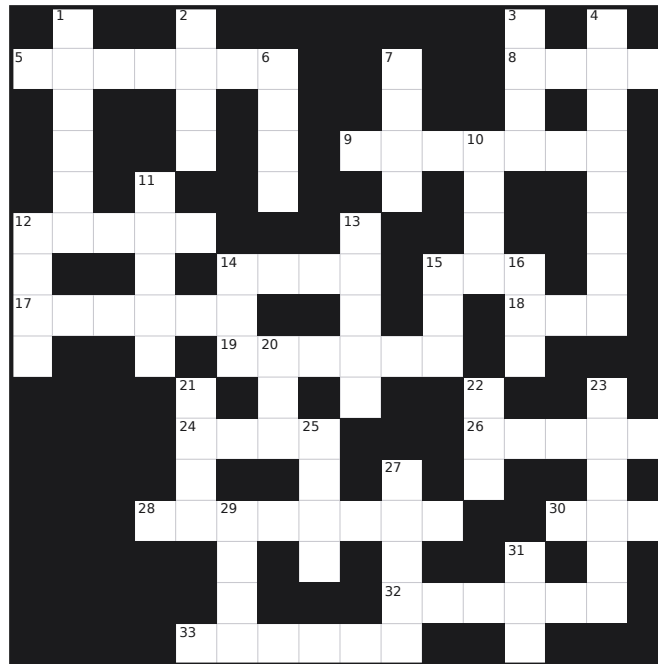
ACROSS

3. Angel ring
6. Dresser
7. What six weeks of couch delivered
8. Where the guys take you to have feelings about it
10. What her mother does about the new one
12. What you didn't do, per your lawyer's letter
14. Pronoun you now use for the dog
16. What her roommate did when you walked in
18. Liquid coping, served in a pint
19. Paper evidence of the forty bucks you borrowed
20. The mode you claim to be in now
22. The excuse for skipping her cousin's wedding
23. Fire leftover
24. What she said would help. You did one class.
27. Walking speed
28. Nearby
29. What you did with the show you watched together

DOWN

1. Breathing organ
2. Thick
3. Physical contact from a guy friend, two pats maximum
4. What you are. Entirely.
5. Grazing field
9. The lads
11. Singing group
13. What Sunday delivers, generously
15. What is currently being divided in a driveway
16. Possessive you can't say anymore without an eye roll
17. State of the union, and of your playlist
20. The other one
21. How your date described your date
25. What you claim to be when the check arrives
26. How the mirror reports you

The Dog Is Fine, By the Way



ACROSS

5. What her dog is doing to you, constantly
8. Crying, but with visible chest movement
9. Guard
12. Self-description with a rotating hobby attached
14. To get left at the altar
15. Her family, as described to the guys
17. What the wellness podcast told you to repeat
18. What you shaved three years off of online
19. What you said you'd be doing 'soon' for nine months
24. What you claim to do at her friend's brunch
26. What your ex said you were to your best friend
28. What you did at 3 a.m. with a phone in your hand
30. What you do in the car in the parking garage
32. Cure
33. Mars or Venus

DOWN

1. Small eatery
2. What you are to a buddy, and also what you eat
3. What you walk down at everyone else's wedding
4. Hindrance
6. What you eat at 2 a.m. instead of feelings
7. What you feel like, and your odds, per her
10. The best thing about Tuesday now
11. What you do at your roommate for 40 minutes
12. What you found where your heart used to be
13. Step
14. What you were in, financially and emotionally
15. What you made of yourself on her Instagram
16. Where you go to forget, or to remember very loudly
20. What you are at three in the morning
21. What happens to your stuff during a breakup
22. What you loudly promised to get
23. What you became at other people's brunches
25. Soap bubbles
27. What she broke, allegedly, per your bio
29. Worshipped figure
31. Put down

Things You Swore You Would Do

Tick what you actually did. Be honest. Nobody is reading this but you and possibly your brother, who will absolutely tell everyone.

- ☐ Run a marathon (started: a 4k, in October, in the rain)
- ☐ Learn to cook something that is not eggs
- ☐ Delete her number (you still know it by heart)
- ☐ Get the dog back (legally impossible, emotionally necessary)
- ☐ Take up a hobby (bought the equipment, never opened the box)
- ☐ Apologise to her brother (he was fine with it the whole time)
- ☐ Grow a beard (it came in patchy; it has been described as 'moss')
- ☐ Move to a new city (moved apartments, same block, same view of her parking spot)
- ☐ Be friends with her (you cannot, and that is allowed)
- ☐ Be genuinely happy for her (working on it, in the gym)
- ☐ Say one sentence about it without mentioning her name
- ☐ Sleep before one a.m. for four nights in a row

SELF ASSESSMENT

The Scorecard

Fill this in after puzzle 8. Numbers do not lie, and yours are hilarious.

Hours spent thinking about her

Estimated. Add ten percent for shower time.

___ / ___

Texts sent to her

Across any and all apps, including the one you deleted

___ / ___

Unsent drafts written and deleted

The real hero number of the whole breakup

___ / ___

Times the playlist played end to end

If over 40, see a professional

___ / ___

Gym visits claimed / gym visits actual

Be honest. Two numbers, both surprising.

___ / ___

Times you explained the breakup to a stranger

Includes the barber, who did not ask

___ / ___

Songs skipped because they got to you

Count the ones by that band from college

___ / ___

Group chat messages sent after midnight

Roughly equal to the number of bad ideas

___ / ___

Final score: whatever you wrote, add 40 points for finishing the book.

Things You Will Not Say Out Loud

PART TWO

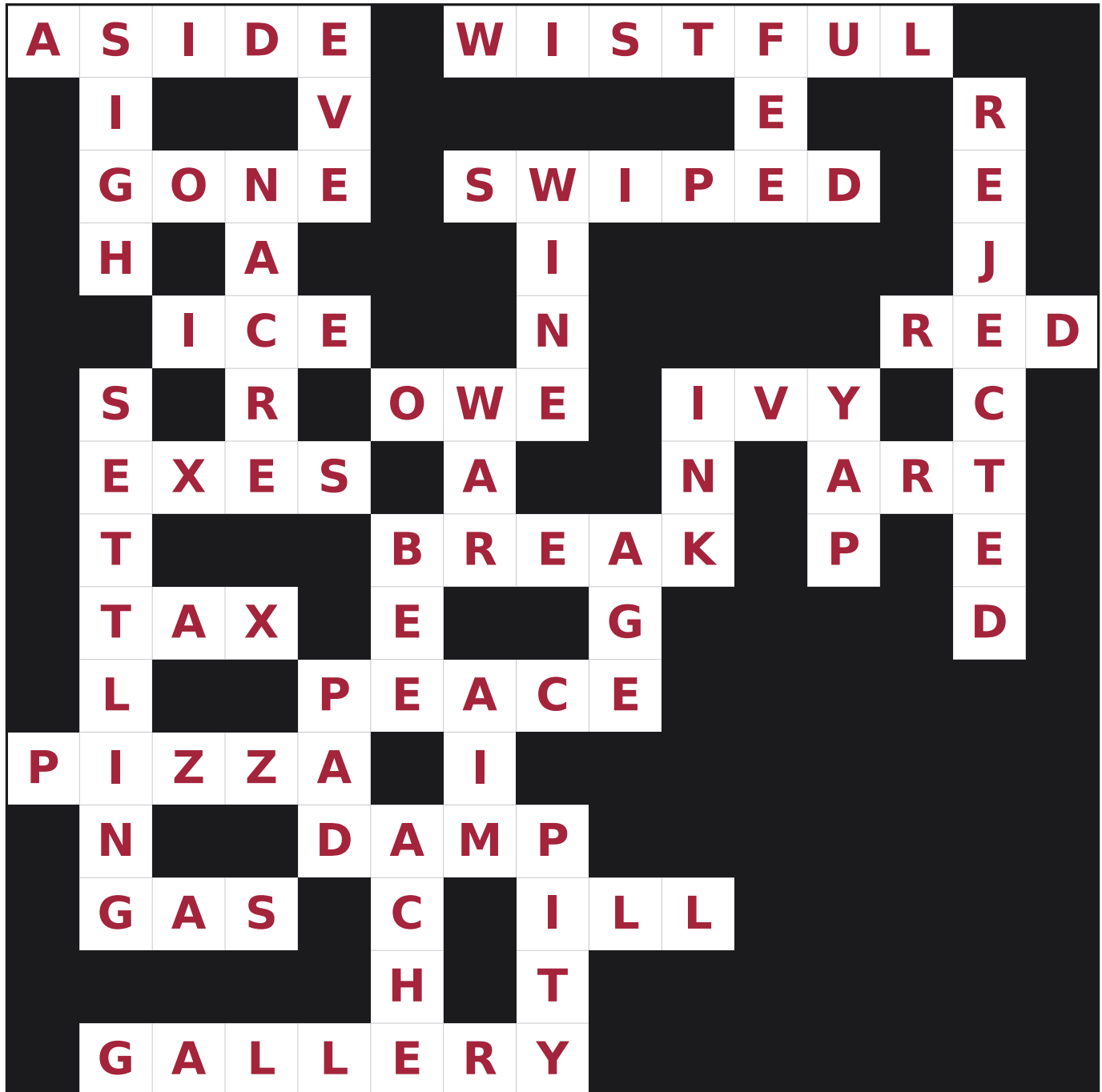
The Answers, Admitted

Every answer, every grid, no judgement.

Try not to arrive here before the first hour is up.

The Answers, Admitted

PUZZLE 1 — It's Not You, It's the Puzzle



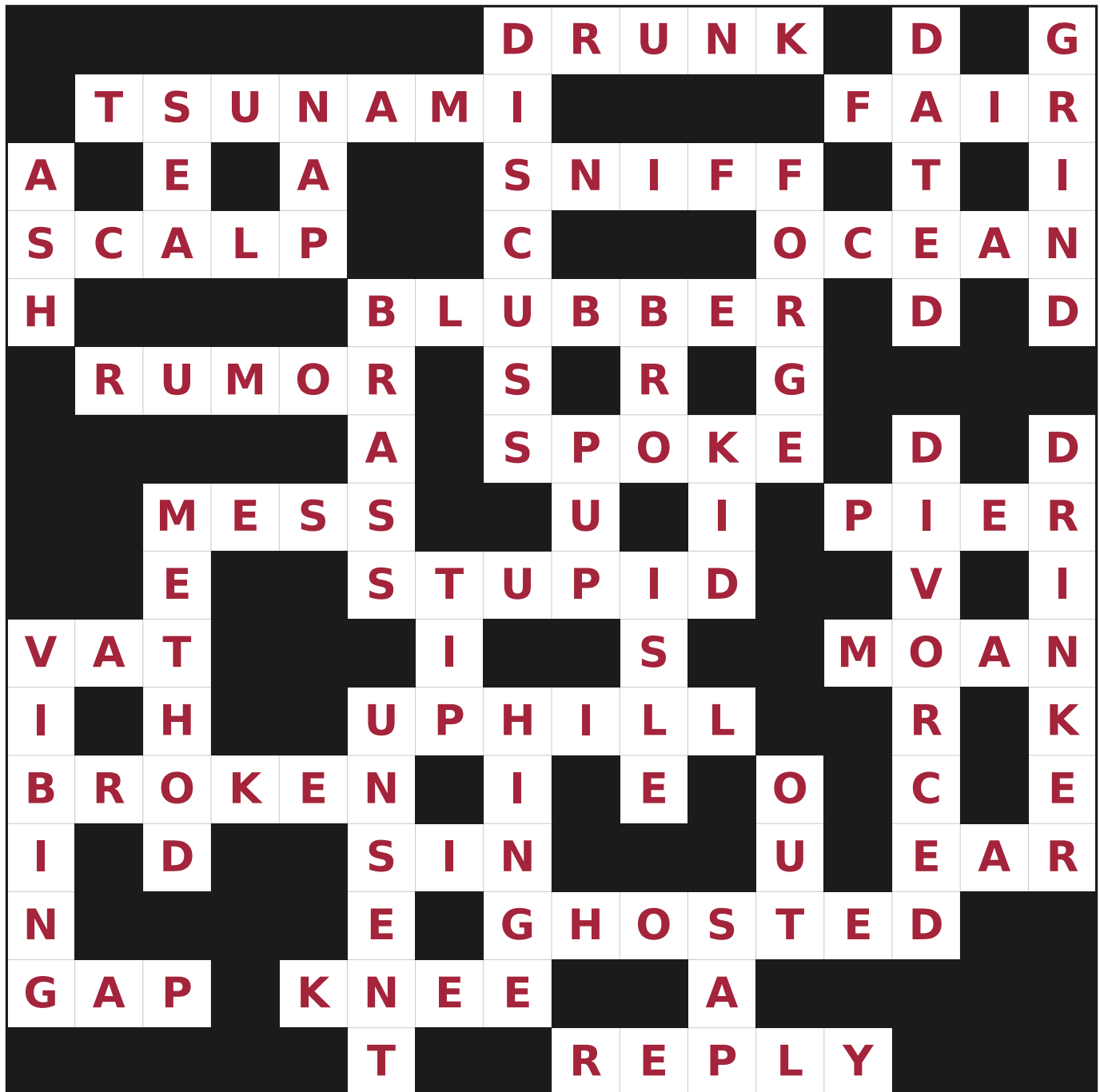
The Answers, Admitted

PUZZLE 2 — The Five Stages, in Ink



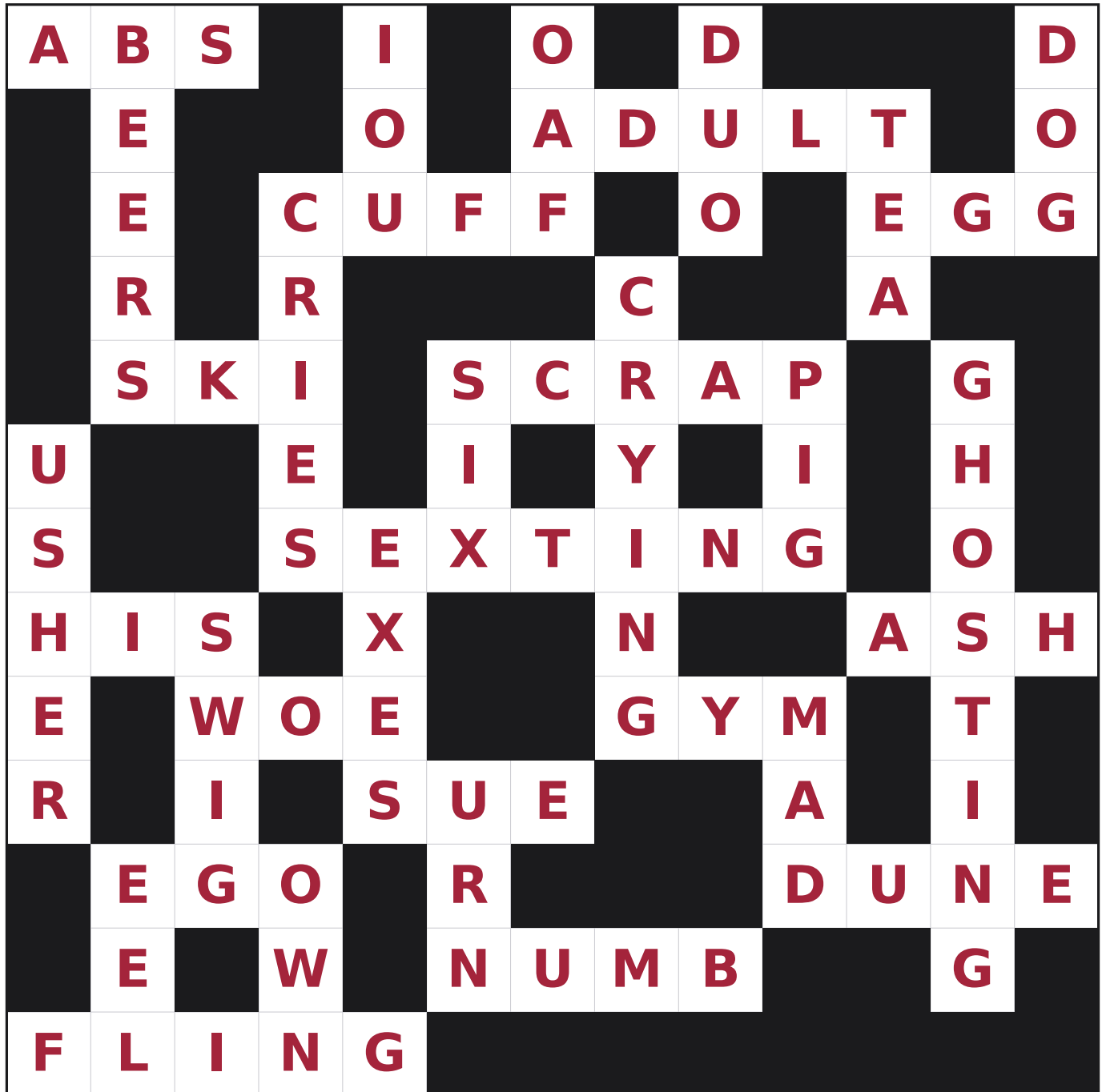
The Answers, Admitted

PUZZLE 3 — Two A.M. Typing Lessons



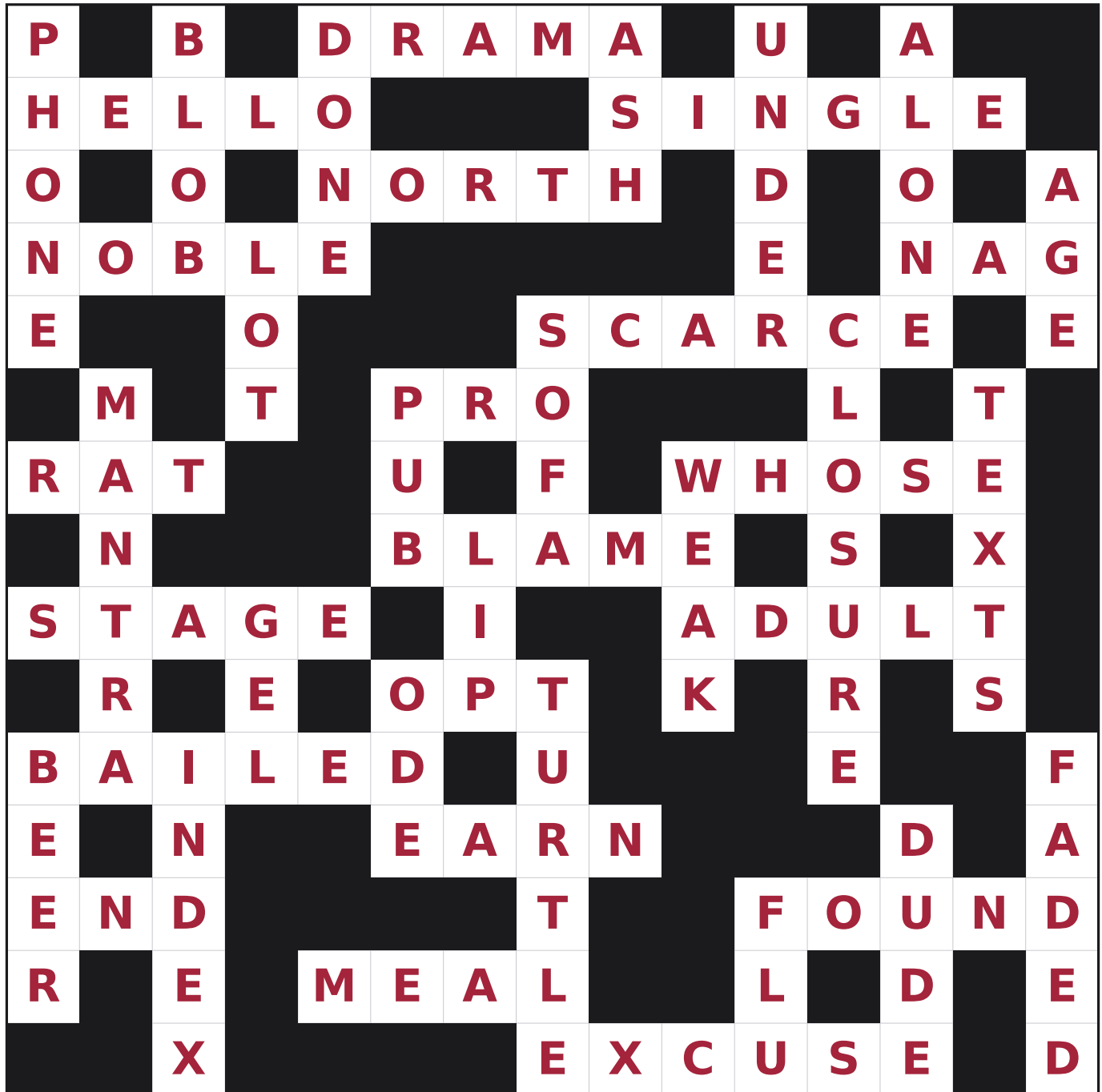
The Answers, Admitted

PUZZLE 4 — The Group Chat Is Typing...



The Answers, Admitted

PUZZLE 5 — She Took the Dog



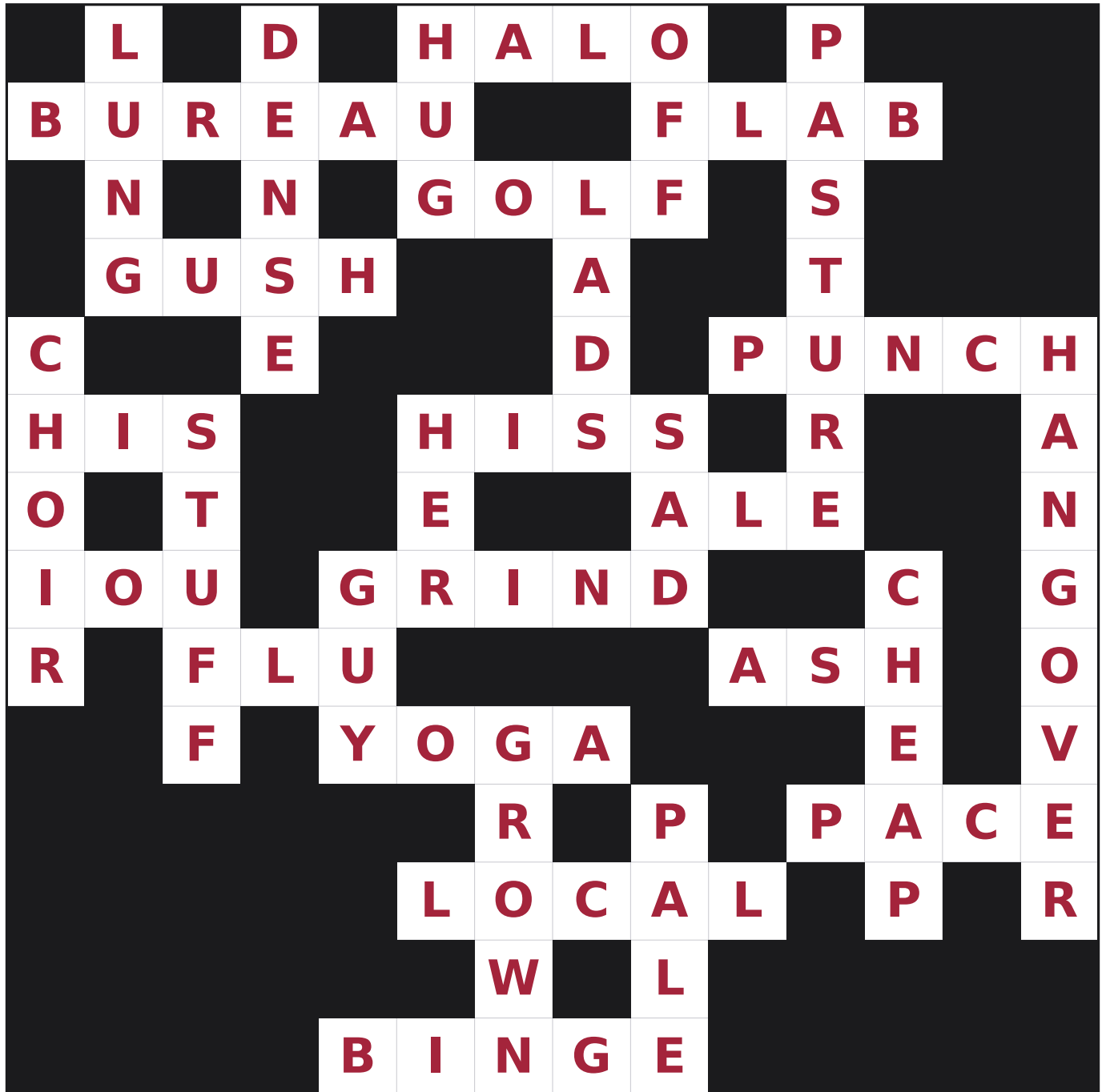
The Answers, Admitted

PUZZLE 6 — Blocked, Unblocked, Blocked



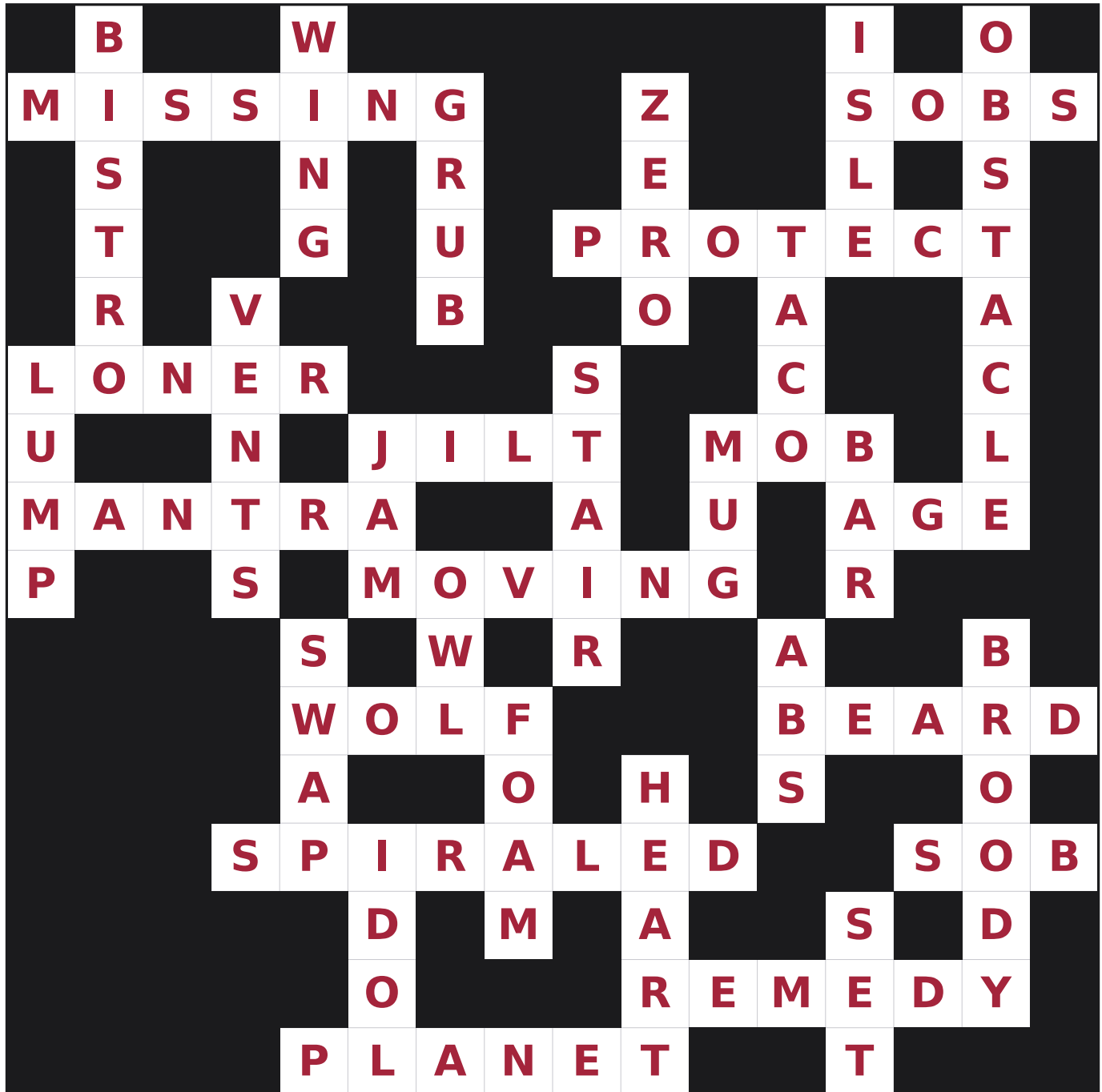
The Answers, Admitted

PUZZLE 7 — Closure (Not Included)



The Answers, Admitted

PUZZLE 8 — The Dog Is Fine, By the Way



ONE LAST THING

You finished it.

Eight puzzles. You did them. You are, statistically, fine now.

Somewhere around puzzle four you stopped thinking about her and started thinking about a four-letter word for 'the guy she told you not to worry about.' That is growth. That is practically a hobby.

If you laughed even once, this book did its job. If you cried once, that was the postage, and nobody in the group chat needs to hear about it.

Put it on a shelf. Buy a copy for a friend who is going through it. Tell him you found it in a store and thought of him, which is a lie, and also the nicest thing you will do all year.

THE EX-FILES

Crosswords for the recently single, the long recovered, and anyone who needs a gift for a man who is 'totally fine.'